

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

## CORE FORMULA

Ask if they want advice -> Wait for yes -> Give it once -> Stop

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before giving advice, ask: 'Would it be useful to hear my view on that?' Wait for the answer. If yes, give your advice once and stop.

## BEST FOR

- Coaching or mentoring relationships
- Advising friends or family on personal matters
- Situations where your advice was not requested
- Any conversation where someone is processing a problem

## PHRASE BANK

### Ask Permission · Before advising

- "Would it be useful to hear my view on that?"
- "Do you want input, or do you want me to just listen?"
- "Are you looking for a suggestion or just thinking out loud?"
- "I have a thought — want to hear it?"
- "Should I weigh in or would you rather work through it yourself?"
- "Do you want advice, or do you want me to hold the space?"
- "Is this a moment where input would help, or a moment where you need to talk?"

### Give Once and Stop · After they say yes

- "My view is X — that is it."
- "One thought: ..."
- "I will say it once: ..."
- "My honest read is X. Take it or leave it."
- "I do not want to repeat it — but my advice is..."

### Quick Permission Asks · Low-key ways to check first

- "Want a thought on that?"
- "Open to a suggestion?"
- "Shall I weigh in?"
- "Want my read, or just an ear?"
- "Say the word if you want ideas."
- "I have a view when you want it."

### Workplace Permission · Advising colleagues without overstepping

- "Would a recommendation from me be useful here, or is this one yours to work through?"
- "I have seen a version of this before — want the comparison?"
- "Do you want my input now, or once you have a draft?"
- "This is your call to make. Would an outside view help?"
- "Before I offer anything — what kind of input would actually be useful?"
- "I can share how I would approach it, if that helps rather than muddies."

### Advice Repair · When you advised without asking

- "I jumped straight to advice there — I should have asked first."

- "You wanted to be heard and I handed you a to-do list. Let me just listen."
- "Scrap the advice for a moment — tell me more about what is going on."
- "I have given you my view twice now. I will drop it — it is your decision."
- "I asked if you wanted input and then talked over your no. That was not fair."
- "Ignore my suggestion if it does not fit — you know this situation better than I do."

## WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Unsolicited advice immediately: 'What you need to do is...'  
Better: Can I share a thought?  
**Best: Do you want advice on that, or would you rather think it through yourself?**
2. Weak: Repeating advice they did not take  
Better: I know I said this before, but...  
**Best: Give advice once. If they do not take it, accept their choice.**
3. Weak: Framing advice as a question to smuggle it in: 'Have you thought about doing X?'  
Better: You might want to consider X.  
**Best: Direct advice clearly labelled as advice, given once, after asking permission.**

## DECISION TREE

### If Someone tells you about a problem and you have a solution

Ask if they want the advice before giving it.

*"I have a thought on that — would it help to hear it?"*

### If They say no to advice

Respect it. Do not give the advice anyway.

*"That is fine — I am here if you want to talk it through."*

### If They say yes and you give advice

Give it once. Do not repeat it if they do not take it.

*"My advice is X. I will leave it at that."*

### If They keep coming back with the same problem and not taking your advice

Do not repeat the same advice. Ask what they are actually looking for.

*"I notice we keep coming back to this — what would actually help right now?"*

## SCENARIOS

### Friend venting about a problem you could easily solve

Ask first whether they want input or just to be heard. — "I have an idea that might help — want to hear it, or would you rather I just listen?"

### Junior colleague struggling with a task

Check whether they want help or to work it out themselves. — "I can see you are working through this — do you want input, or would you rather get there yourself?"

### Parent advising adult child

Ask before advising, genuinely accept no. — "I have a view on this — do you want to hear it?"

### You have already given advice they have not followed

Do not repeat it. Ask what they need instead. — "I gave you my view on this last time — I will not repeat it. What are you looking for right now?"

## WHEN NOT TO USE

- In emergencies where there is no time for permission — give the critical information immediately.
- In professional contexts where giving advice is literally your role (consultant, doctor, manager giving direction).
- When the permission question itself would feel clinical or awkward in a close personal relationship.

## 7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

**Day 1 — Notice the urge to advise**

Notice every time today when you feel the urge to give advice. Do not give it yet — just notice.

**Day 2 — Ask first**

In one conversation, ask if the person wants your advice before giving it.

**Day 3 — Accept no**

If they say no, accept it genuinely. Do not give the advice anyway or hint at it.

**Day 4 — Give once**

When you give advice, say it once and stop. Do not repeat it.

**Day 5 — The listening alternative**

When they say they want to be heard rather than advised, practise just listening.

**Day 6 — Repeated advice audit**

Notice any advice you have given more than once. Stop giving it. Ask what they actually need.

**Day 7 — Calibration**

Was advice received better when asked for? Did accepting 'no' change the relationship? Did you repeat any advice?

**AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST**

- Did I ask if they wanted advice before giving it?
- Did I genuinely accept if they said no?
- Did I give the advice once and not repeat it?
- Did I avoid framing advice as questions?
- Did I resist the urge to give advice they had not asked for?
- Did people seem more receptive to advice when they had asked for it?
- Did I offer to just listen rather than advise when that was what was needed?